

everything. The number of nongay drinkers of cheap white wine who find it's not required that they use a deodorant. The increase in Spanish-surnamed modern females without hangovers who sleep late on Wednesdays even though the alarm goes off. I don't believe it either. But the Federal Reserve Board really *does* say they have a handle on net-worth numbers, and they break them down by age. I had to massage their data and make a few guesses. But it turns out that nearly 2.5 million of America's 70 million households are headed by people under 55 years old with a net worth of \$250,000 or more. After allowing for single heads of households, that's about 4 million people with close to the target net worth of \$400,000. Those 4 million people have the luxury of continuing to work only if they feel like it.

I suspect that most of the 4 million people got their wealth the same way I did, by getting a good education, working hard, and having a little luck. That's what's so great about opportunities in America. Four million people—the population of a city the size of Chicago—have earned so much money so early in life that they can hang 'em up after only a dozen years of work. That doesn't happen in other countries.

If you're anything like I was before I retired, your personal balance sheet may show a net worth of \$400,000 or \$500,000. You have to update the value of your home, but you get there. You're one of the 4 million. If you're not, chapter 10 tells how to build your net worth over the next several years. But having \$500,000 of net worth doesn't mean you have \$40,000 in interest income, does it? Hell no. That net worth is tied up in your house, your car, your investments, and your sensible life insurance program. And anyway, you couldn't possibly live on \$40,000 a year, right? You've got two career earners in the family, both busting their asses, knocking down a combined \$100,000 a year, and your December Bloomingdale's bill was so high you could barely afford to tip the doormen at Christmas.

I know. I was there. But my accountant's instincts drove